



AI Playbook and Toolkit for Public Health Departments

Vendor Coordination and Operational Handoff for AI Pilots

PGM 140

This module helps program managers coordinate vendors and internal teams during AI pilots and operational handoff. It focuses on requirements, data boundaries, roles, communication, documentation, acceptance criteria, training, support, and transition from vendor demonstration to agency-owned operations. It does not provide legal or procurement advice and does not assume a specific vendor or approved tool.

Level	applied
Primary track	Program Management Track
Appears in tracks	program-management

Learning Objectives

- Describe the program manager role in coordinating AI vendors and internal reviewers.
- Identify information that must be clarified before vendor demonstrations, pilots, or operational handoff.
- Develop acceptance criteria and support expectations for an AI-supported workflow.
- Create a vendor coordination and handoff checklist for an AI pilot.

Module Overview

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Jurisdiction and Agency Policy Note

This national-level training module is intended for public health education, planning, and workforce development. It does not replace agency policy, legal review, privacy review, security review, procurement review, communications clearance, civil rights review, Tribal consultation, or governance approval. Learners should confirm applicable requirements, approved tools, data rules, and review pathways within their own jurisdiction and organization before implementing AI-supported workflows.

Why This Topic Matters for Public Health AI

AI vendor coordination is not only a procurement activity. Once a vendor is involved, program managers often need to coordinate requirements, data rules, workflow design, testing, training, user feedback, issue tracking, and handoff to operations. If these details are not managed, a promising pilot can become dependent on undocumented vendor assumptions or informal staff workarounds. The agency must remain accountable for public health purpose, data protection, human review, and operational decisions.

Operational handoff is the point where responsibility moves from design or pilot activity into routine use or ongoing support. Handoff can fail when staff do not know who owns the workflow, how to report issues, what the vendor supports, who monitors performance, or what happens when the tool changes. Program managers help prevent this by defining acceptance criteria, documentation, training, support channels, and governance reporting before the pilot ends. This makes scale or continuation a deliberate decision.

Public Health Example

A health department contracts with a vendor to pilot an AI-assisted document classification tool for internal records. The program manager creates a handoff checklist requiring approved data boundaries, test results, user training, role-based access, issue reporting, vendor support hours, documentation of model limitations, and governance review of pilot outcomes. During testing, staff discover that the tool performs poorly on scanned documents. The acceptance criteria prevent the workflow from moving to routine use until the limitation is documented and a mitigation plan is approved.

Technical, Programmatic, and Operational Deep Dive

Before vendor engagement, the program manager should clarify the use case, workflow, data boundaries, and review requirements. Vendor demonstrations should not use real sensitive data unless explicitly approved. The team should ask how the vendor handles data, prompts, files, logs, model updates, security controls, access, retention, performance monitoring, and incident response. Program managers should coordinate with procurement, legal, IT,

privacy, security, and governance reviewers rather than trying to answer these questions alone.

During a pilot, coordination should be structured. The program manager should maintain a decision log, issue log, change log, training log, and list of open risks. They should define who can communicate requirements to the vendor, who can approve changes, and how user feedback is triaged. This prevents conflicting instructions and helps the vendor understand what matters for public health operations.

Operational handoff requires more than a final meeting. Staff need documentation, training, standard operating procedures, escalation paths, monitoring responsibilities, and clarity about vendor support. The handoff should identify what is agency-owned, what is vendor-supported, and what must return to governance if it changes. This is especially important for AI systems because vendor model updates, data changes, or workflow changes can affect performance and risk.

Risks, Failure Modes, and Guardrails

A common failure mode is allowing vendor capabilities to define agency requirements. If the team adapts the public health workflow to what the vendor wants to demonstrate, the project may lose connection to the original problem. Guardrails include internal requirements, governance conditions, and acceptance criteria before vendor work proceeds. Program managers should keep the public health purpose visible in every vendor discussion.

Another risk is unclear data handling. Staff may provide sample files, screenshots, or exports without understanding whether the vendor environment is approved. Guardrails include approved data boundaries, synthetic or de-identified test data where appropriate, and review by privacy, security, and legal staff. Any change in data use should trigger review.

A third risk is weak handoff. If support, monitoring, training, and ownership are unclear, the workflow may fail after the pilot team moves on. Guardrails include handoff checklists, support models, escalation pathways, and governance reporting. The agency should not accept a workflow that cannot be safely operated and monitored.

Application to AI-Supported Workflows

This module applies when an AI use case involves external vendors, contractors, consultants, or technology partners. The program manager should coordinate internal review and vendor communication while respecting procurement and legal boundaries. The handoff checklist should be completed before routine use begins. The module also supports teams using internal tools because operational handoff is still necessary when moving from pilot to routine work.

Reflection Questions

What vendor assumptions could affect an AI-supported public health workflow?

What acceptance criteria should be met before a pilot is considered complete?

What information should be included in an operational handoff checklist?

Practical Exercise

Create a vendor coordination and operational handoff checklist for an AI pilot. Include data boundaries, approved-tool requirements, roles, communication rules, acceptance criteria, training, issue reporting, vendor support, monitoring, documentation, and governance decision points.

Example: For an AI-assisted records classification pilot, the checklist might require synthetic test files for early testing, privacy/security review before any real data use, acceptance criteria for classification accuracy and reviewer burden, user training, an issue log, and a handoff meeting with IT support and program owners.

Expected Artifact or Evidence

Vendor coordination and handoff checklist.

Acceptance criteria for one AI-supported workflow.

Issue and decision log template outline.

Knowledge Check

- 1. What should guide vendor discussions?
- 2. Why are acceptance criteria important?
- 3. What should happen before using real sensitive data in a vendor environment?
- 4. What belongs in operational handoff?
- 5. What is one risk of weak handoff?

References and Resources

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